

Chapter 140-3

//

On Wednesday, after Liang Shi dropped Xu Qingzhu off at work, she drove to the entrance of the media school to pick up Liang Wanwan.

When Liang Wanwan learned she was going to Chen Mian's art exhibition, she was very excited at first. Later, for some unknown reason, her mood became unusually low. After much deliberation, she still decided to go to the exhibition with Liang Shi.

This was Liang Wanwan's last year at school—she was about to graduate soon. The dual pressure of her thesis and job hunting left her with no leisure time.

She didn't even know that Liang Shi had been in a coma for so long before.

She spent most of her time in the classroom, studio, and dormitory. There hadn't been any long holidays recently, so she hadn't even gone back to the Liang family home.

Liang Shi waited at the school entrance for less than two minutes before Liang Wanwan, wearing a white down jacket, appeared at the school gate.

She was carrying a light gray backpack, wearing a white down jacket, a gray knitted hat, and white knee-high boots—a very youthful and beautiful outfit.

Liang Shi honked the horn.

Liang Wanwan jogged over a few steps, opened the car door, and got in. She pressed her hands against her rosy red cheeks and asked gently: "Jie, is it just the two of us?"

"Mm." Liang Shi said: "Chen Mian only gave me two tickets."

"Alright." Liang Wanwan started fastening her seatbelt.

Along the way, Liang Wanwan, as a semi-"insider," gave Liang Shi some knowledge about art exhibitions.

Especially about this particular exhibition.

As a well-known eccentric genius painter in the industry, Chen Mian's works weren't usually displayed at exhibitions for viewing.

Most of the time, they would appear online or in various competitions.

The thirteen "eccentric genius" painters at this exhibition were all recognized in the industry for their strange painting styles, which could be called absurdist.

But they were different from what was commonly referred to as absurdism in literature.

Absurdism in literature is often satirical, either criticizing current affairs or discussing human nature.

But these painters' strangeness was only in their painting style—either too dark or too bright.

Yet there was nothing wrong with their composition and colors; in fact, they were quite outstanding.

That's why they were praised as "eccentric geniuses."

Among them, the most frequently nominated were Chen Mian and Qin Lishuang.

Chen Mian was famous for her strange landscape paintings.

Qin Lishuang was famous for her strange portraits.

Qin Lishuang was particularly skilled at capturing people's most fearful or darkest moments.

Meanwhile, Chen Mian's paintings had very deep artistic conception.

Originally, there was no point in comparing the two, but one year at an international competition, there were four nominees in total, and Chen Mian, as the youngest, won the award.

That year, everyone had been most optimistic about Qin Lishuang.

Not only that, but two months later, there was another international competition.

The work Qin Lishuang entered was one she had said in an interview was her most satisfying piece. At that time, she was very confident, saying she had a ninety percent chance of winning. But Chen Mian cut in—the only two nominees were Qin Lishuang and Chen Mian.

In the end, Chen Mian won.

Chen Mian, as a newcomer, rose rapidly in the art world.

No one could imitate her painting style.

And reportedly, the work she entered that time was something she had casually painted after drinking too much.

After that, Chen Mian's name frequently appeared in the public eye, becoming as renowned as Qin Lishuang, and later even showing signs of surpassing her.

Qin Lishuang had dominated for so many years—naturally, she couldn't stand someone being so much better than her.

So Chen Mian became a thorn in her side.

Almost every competition Chen Mian entered, Qin Lishuang would also enter.

Later, nothing so dramatic happened again. It was often a case of Chen Mian winning one round and Qin Lishuang winning the next.

Over time, Chen Mian and Qin Lishuang's names became bound together—praising one inevitably meant putting down the other.

Liang Wanwan educated Liang Shi the whole way, finally summarizing: "I don't like Qin Lishuang's painting style either. It's too dark."

"But she has a lot of fans online." Liang Wanwan said: "She's quite good-looking—the mature, cool big sister type."

Liang Shi had just pulled up to the entrance of the art museum.

The exhibition started at ten o'clock, and many people had already arrived by now.

Men and women were gathered in the open space in front of the art museum, chatting casually.

Liang Shi and Liang Wanwan waited quietly until ticket checking began over there.

After having their tickets checked and entering, the venue was unusually quiet.

The organizers had rented two floors for the exhibition, with all kinds of paintings hanging on the walls.

Because it was a fairly famous exhibition in the industry, many people came. Liang Wanwan even ran into her major course professor.

However, they didn't see Chen Mian, Qin Lishuang, or any of the other artists.

Liang Wanwan basically recognized all these painters' faces and said not a single one of them had come.

But she heard from her professor that today's exhibition would also have experience-sharing sessions, though it hadn't been decided who would participate. At least three to five of those painters would show up.

Liang Shi had specifically asked Chen Mian.

Chen Mian said she would come, just a bit later.

The paintings on the walls weren't within Liang Shi's range of appreciation. What she was interested in were Chen Mian's and Qin Lishuang's paintings.

Below each painting was an introduction related to the work.

Other painters had quite lengthy introductions, including the creative intent and meaning behind the painting.

But when it came to Chen Mian's, there were only two characters: Chen Mian.

Everything else was blank.

Qin Lishuang's was also rather sparse—aside from her name, there was only the creation date.